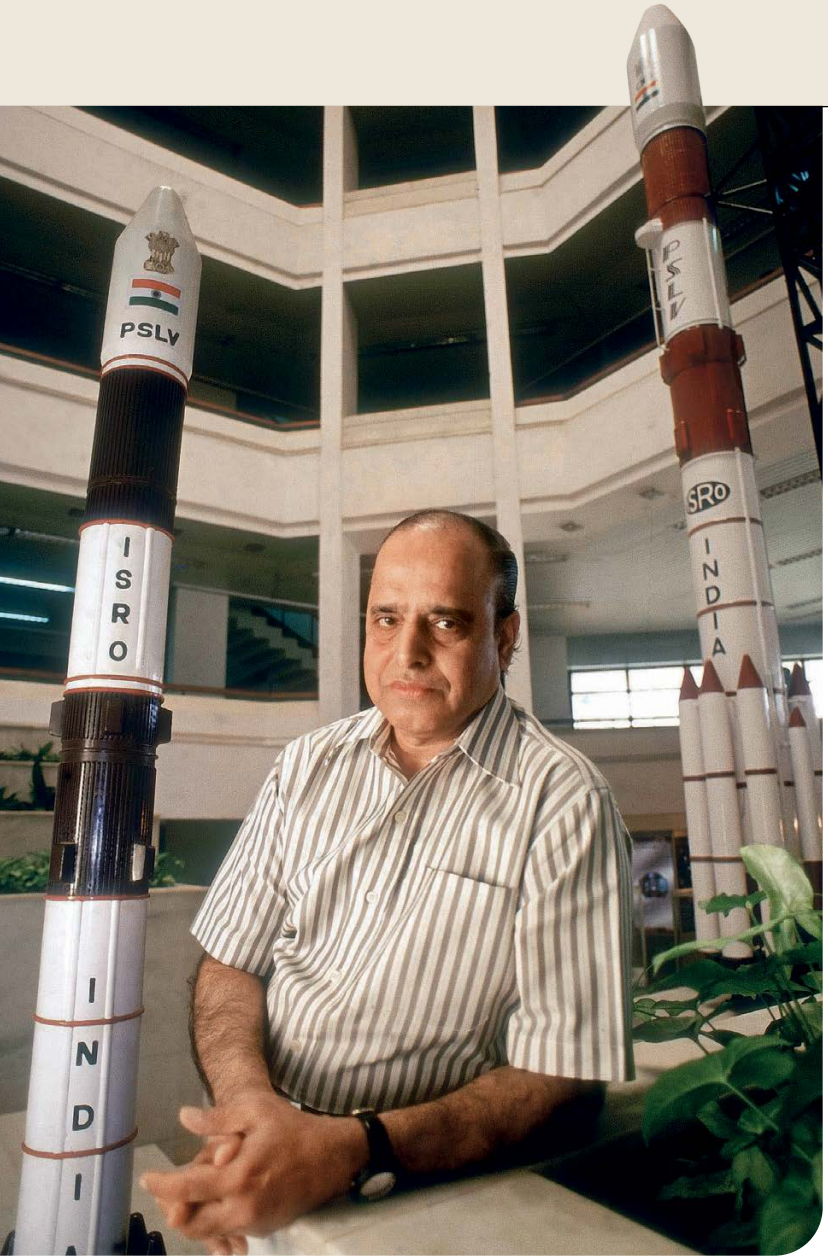


C RAMESH



R. CHIDAMBARAM | b. 1936 |

Nuclear scientist

Rajagopala Chidambaram stood at the quiet centre of India's nuclear story, a physicist trusted with its most consequential secrets. He helped shape the country's first nuclear test in 1974, codenamed Smiling Buddha, and oversaw Pokhran-II, or Operation Shakti, in 1998, at the helm of the Department of Atomic Energy. A former BARC director, where he initiated the supercomputer programme, and a long-serving Principal Scientific Advisor to the GoI, he exercised authority with a genteel manner and believed deeply in scientific self-reliance to drive national development.

NAVIN CHAWLA | b. 1945 |

Former Chief Election Commissioner of India

After a copybook elite educational trajectory—Sanawar, Stephen's, SOAS, LSE, Oxford—Navin Chawla segued smoothly to the bureaucratic life, where he finally rose to high constitutional office, that of Chief Election Commissioner. In the 1990s, as a joint secretary in the I&B ministry, his were the hands that parted the curtains for India's open-skies policies. His tenure as CEC was a more contested one, with questions about institutional neutrality. Chawla, who in response insisted on strict adherence to legality over perceived perfection, was influenced by Mother Teresa and wrote a biography on her.



SOUMITRA GHOSH